communication equipment. One of Captain Carretera's rockets struck the ammunition on board. As the crew abandoned ship, the *Rio Escondido* exploded. The other ships of the CEF withdrew, and two, the *Caribe* and the *Atlantico*, headed for the open sea.

Over the next two days the brigade fought off determined attacks from Castro's troops and militia. Without air support, supply of ammunition was limited to ineffective air drops. When, in the aftermath of the operation, Fidel Castro was asked why the landing had failed, he promptly replied, 'lack of air cover'.[52] Kennedy did permit some air operations over the beachhead at Playa Giron (though not against Cuban airfields), but as the B-26s were bombers, they were of limited use in air combat. More importantly, they were of virtually no use against the T-33 jets. The CIA had discounted the combat capabilities of the trainers and failed to anticipate they could be adapted to carry rockets and heavy machine guns.[53] The piston-engined B-26s were no match for the supersonic T-33s.

With the operation on the brink of failure, Kennedy refused to commit the Skyhawks from the USS *Essex* waiting outside Cuban territorial waters, much to the angst and anger of the Chief of Naval Operations, Admiral Burke. The commander of Brigade 2506, Jose Perez San Roman ('Pepe'), had received assurances of US military support from various US officials. Pepe continued to plead for air cover until his beleaguered forces were overrun.

The CIA had been repeatedly told by the President that he would not countenance overt US involvement. Despite his public declarations, key officials failed to understand that he meant what he said. For those steeped in the arts of plausible deniability, public denials were but part of the choreography.

Eventually, with collapse imminent on the morning of 19 April, Kennedy was prevailed upon to provide token support for the brigade. Six unmarked Skyhawks from the *Essex* flew over the beachhead in support of the attacking B-26s (though with rules of engagement that precluded seeking air combat). Even this token gesture proved futile. Failure to factor in the time difference between Cuba and Nicaragua (from where the bombers